Youssef Benzarti

Department of Economics, University of California, Santa Barbara
Santa Barbara, CA 93106
benzarti@ucsb.edu • www.benzarti.com

Citizenship: Morocco, Tunisia, United States. November 2026
Research and teaching fields: Public finance.

Academic Appointments

University of California, Santa Barbara — *Associate Professor of Economics* July 2022 – present
Public Finance Lab, UCSB — *Director* July 2024 – present
National Bureau of Economic Research — *Research Associate* September 2026 – present
National Bureau of Economic Research — *Faculty Research Fellow* May 2017 – September 2026
University of California, Santa Barbara — *Assistant Professor of Economics* July 2018 – June 2022
University of California, Los Angeles — *Assistant Professor of Economics* July 2016 – June 2018
California Center for Population Research — *Faculty Affiliate* July 2016 – June 2018

Editorial Responsibilities

Review of Economics and Statistics — Associate Editor April 2025 – present
European Economic Review — Associate Editor Nov. 2022 – Sept. 2025

Visits

Brown University — *Department of Economics* January – May 2020
University of Michigan — *Office of Tax Policy Research* September 2017

Education

University of California, Berkeley — PhD in Economics 2016
Dissertation committee: Emmanuel Saez, Alan Auerbach and Stefano DellaVigna.
Paris School of Economics — MA in Economics 2010
HEC Paris — MSc in Management 2009

Book

The Tax Mirage. Under contract, Princeton University Press. A general-reader book on tax incidence: who actually bears American taxes, and why the political debate gets it wrong.

Publications

1. Benzarti, Youssef and Dorian Carloni. "Who Really Benefits from Consumption Tax Cuts? Evidence from a Large VAT Reform in France." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, February 2019. NBER Working Paper No. 23848.
2. Benzarti, Youssef, Jarkko Harju and Tuomas Matikka. "Does Mandating Social Insurance Affect Entrepreneurial Activity?" *American Economic Review: Insights*, June 2020. NBER Working Paper No. 25651.

3. Benzarti, Youssef. "How Taxing Is Tax Filing? Using Revealed Preferences to Estimate Compliance Costs." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, November 2020. NBER Working Paper No. 23903.
4. Benzarti, Youssef, Dorian Carloni, Jarkko Harju and Tuomas Kosonen. "What Goes Up May Not Come Down: Asymmetric Incidence of Value Added Taxes." *Journal of Political Economy*, December 2020. NBER Working Paper No. 23849.
5. Benzarti, Youssef. "Estimating the Costs of Filing Tax Returns and the Potential Savings from Policies Aimed at Reducing These Costs." *Tax Policy and the Economy*, 2021, Vol. 35. NBER Working Paper No. 27946.
6. Benzarti, Youssef and Alisa Tazhitdinova. "Do Value-Added Taxes Affect International Trade Flows? Evidence From 30 Years of Tax Reforms." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 2021, 13(4), 469–89. NBER Working Paper No. 26195.
7. Benzarti, Youssef and Jarkko Harju. "Using Payroll Tax Variation to Unpack the Black Box of Firm-Level Production." *Journal of the European Economic Association*, 2021, 19(5), 2737–2764. NBER Working Paper No. 26640.
8. Benzarti, Youssef and Jarkko Harju. "Can Payroll Tax Cuts Help Firms During Recessions?" *Journal of Public Economics*, 2021, 200, 104472. NBER Working Paper No. 27485.
9. Benzarti, Youssef. "Playing Hide and Seek: How Lenders Respond to Borrower Protection." *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 2024, 106(2), 384–393. NBER Working Paper No. 26382.
10. Benzarti, Youssef and Luisa Wallossek. "Rising Income Tax Complexity." *National Tax Journal*, 2024, Vol. 77, No. 1. NBER Working Paper No. 31944.
11. Benzarti, Youssef. "Tax Incidence Anomalies." *Annual Review of Economics*, August 2025. NBER Working Paper No. 32819.
12. Benzarti, Youssef, Santiago Garriga and Dario Tortarolo. "Can VAT Cuts and Anti-Profiteering Measures Dampen the Effects of Food Price Inflation?" June 2024. Conditionally accepted at the *American Economic Review*. NBER Working Paper No. 32241.

Working Papers

13. Benzarti, Youssef, Santiago Garriga and Dario Tortarolo. "Easy to Collect, Costly to Bear: Mobile Money Taxation and Network Spillovers in Tanzania." November 2026.
14. Benzarti, Youssef, Santiago Garriga and Dario Tortarolo. "Path Dependence in the Price Level: Testing Pricing Models with a Fully Reversed VAT Cut." October 2026.
15. Benzarti, Youssef, Jarkko Harju, Ella Mattinen, Tuomas Matikka and Alisa Tazhitdinova. "Moral Hazard and Adverse Selection in the Social Insurance Market for Entrepreneurs." July 2026.
16. Jysmä, Sami, Youssef Benzarti and Jarkko Harju. "Policy Thresholds as Growth Barriers: Theory and Evidence from a Payroll Tax Notch." NBER Working Paper No. 35484, July 2026.
17. Huet-Vaughn, Emiliano and Youssef Benzarti. "Modern US Workers' Compensation and Work-Related Injury: No Evidence of Moral Hazard." NBER Working Paper No. 28187, November 2020.

Work in Progress

Barahona, Nano, Youssef Benzarti, Bernardo Díaz de Astarloa, Ezequiel García-Lembergman, Santiago Garriga, Diego Jiménez-Hernández and Dario Tortarolo. "Equilibrium Effects of Voluntary Price Control Policies."

Expert Testimony

Expert witness in *Federal Trade Commission v. H&R Block* (report and deposition), 2025.

Honors and Awards

Journal of the European Economic Association: Excellence in Refereeing Award 2022
American Economic Review: Insights: Excellence in Refereeing Award 2021, 2022
Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada Grant ($50,800), with Alisa Tazhitdinova 2018
Best Paper, Southern California Conference in Applied Microeconomics 2016
California Center for Population Research Junior Faculty Course Release Program 2016
Outstanding Doctoral Dissertations in Government Finance and Taxation Award, Honorable Mention, National Tax Association 2016
Department of Economics Graduate Student Award for Public Policy Research, UC Berkeley 2016
Center for Equitable Growth Fellowship; Doctoral Completion Fellowship 2015
Russell Sage Foundation Summer Institute in Behavioral Economics 2014
Robert D. Burch Center for Tax Policy and Public Finance Fellowship 2014
Graduate Division Summer Research Grant, UC Berkeley 2011, 2014
Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor, UC Berkeley 2013
Gateway Fellowship, UC Berkeley International House 2011
Department Fellowship, UC Berkeley Department of Economics 2010, 2011
Sandler Fellowship 2010

Invited Presentations

Columbia University; Duke University. 2027
UC Davis; University of Michigan; SITE (Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics). 2026
University of Chicago Harris; University of British Columbia; UC Santa Cruz; EU Tax Observatory Conference (keynote). 2025
University of Iowa; Madrid Public Economics Workshop (keynote). 2024
George Washington University; Texas A&M. 2023
University of Utah; UC Irvine. 2022
Imperial College London; Santa Clara University; Queen Mary University of London. 2021
University of Chicago Harris; NYU Law and Economics; University of South Carolina; NBER Tax Policy and the Economy. 2020
UC Berkeley; ENS Lyon; Southern California Conference in Applied Microeconomics. 2019
University of Oregon; National Tax Association; World Bank. 2018

NBER Summer Institute Public Finance/Labor Studies; Columbia Law School; Cornell; Georgetown; Claremont Graduate School; Cal Poly State University; University of Victoria; University of Warwick; London School of Economics; Institute for Fiscal Studies; University College London; AEA Annual Meetings; Arizona State University; Southern California Conference in Applied Microeconomics; UCSD; UCLA Law School; UCSB.	2017
UCLA; Princeton; Harvard Kennedy School of Government; University of Toronto; University of Massachusetts Amherst; Mathematica; Paris School of Economics (PSI seminar); National Tax Association; University of Michigan; IIPF; NYU/UCLA Tax Policy Symposium.	2016
U.S. Department of the Treasury; SITE Psychology and Economics, Stanford; National Tax Association; Canadian Public Economics Group; Aarhus University; Bay Area Labor and Public Finance Conference; UC Berkeley Public Finance and Psychology and Economics Seminars; McMaster University.	2015
Tax Systems Conference (Michigan and Oxford); Paris 2 (CRED); ENSAE (CREST).	2014
UC Berkeley Psychology and Economics Non-Lunch Seminar.	2013
UC Berkeley Public Finance and Labor Economics Lunch Seminar.	2012

Teaching

University of California, Santa Barbara. Using Big Data to Solve Economic and Social Problems; Intermediate Microeconomics; Introduction to Economics; Graduate Public Finance (Taxation); Graduate Behavioral Public Economics; Graduate Research Seminar; Applied Micro Lunch; Public Finance.

Brown University. Graduate Public Finance — Social Insurance (Spring 2020).

University of California, Los Angeles. Graduate Public Finance (Taxation); Facts About Inequality; Undergraduate Microeconomics; Applied Micro Seminar.

University of California, Berkeley. Undergraduate Game Theory.

Mentoring

Graduate students (placement in parentheses). Sarah Robinson (Claremont McKenna College); Wookun Kim (Southern Methodist University); Matt Fitzgerald (Intensity); Dong Ook Eun (Resolution Economics); Luisa Wallossek (University of Oslo).

PhD defence jury. Santiago Garriga.

Undergraduate students (*placed in a PhD programme). Kazuma Wells (MIT); Jen Kades (Duke*); Sarah Gharbi (Mannheim*); Ziao Ju (Stanford*); Marty Chen (University of Maryland*).

Service

National Bureau of Economic Research. Co-organizer, Public Economics Fall Meeting, 2026.

National Tax Association. Program Committee member, 2021 and 2024.

International Institute of Public Finance. Scientific Committee, 2024.

Department of Economics, UCSB. Undergraduate Committee; Wilcox Chair Search Committee; Graduate Committee; Academic Senate Representative; Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Committee (chair); Hiring Committee.

Department of Economics, UCLA. Graduate Admissions Committee, 2017–2018.

Referee Service

American Economic Journal: Applied Economics; *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*; *American Economic Review*; *American Economic Review: Insights*; *Econometrica*; *Economic Inquiry*; *Economic Journal*; *Economics Letters*; *International Tax and Public Finance*; *Journal of the European Economic Association*; *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*; *Journal of Political Economy*; *Journal of Public Economics*; *Journal of Risk and Insurance*; *National Tax Journal*; *Oxford Economic Papers*; *Quarterly Journal of Economics*; *Review of Economics and Statistics*; *Review of Economic Studies*.

Other

Languages. Arabic (native), English (fluent), French (fluent).

Affiliations. American Economic Association; National Tax Association.